

1930–1940

THE ELEGANT MALE

Just as the female body had become toned and tanned during the 1920s, so the male physique had also been modified into the new ideal shape of wide shoulders, prominent chest, and narrow hips. If wholehearted participation in outdoor sports had failed to produce results, then his suit might do the trick. The master of the flattering cut was the London tailor Frederick Scholte, who distilled three characteristics of the uniform of the Household Cavalry – narrow waists, wide shoulders, and roomy armholes – into what came to be known as the “London cut”. First popularized in the US by the Prince of Wales, this was soon taken up by Hollywood celebrities, who began to displace the British aristocracy and upper class as fashion icons. Double-breasted coats, peaked lapels, and striped suiting were popular, as they further helped to achieve the desired athletic silhouette.

SUITS FOR WOMEN

In a famous scene from the 1930 film *Morocco*, Marlene Dietrich, playing a nightclub singer, performed in a black tailcoat. Dietrich also wore suits off-screen and her studio exploited her style. Publicity photos showed Dietrich in a grey suit with black turtle-neck sweater and beret, and the star turned up for a film premiere in a tuxedo. Dietrich's preference was said to have started a trend, but formal trousers for women did not really catch on.



1930

Derby Day In the 1930s morning coats would rarely have been seen on city streets but were still worn at the races. Here, Sir John Buchanan-Jardine has chosen a double-breasted waistcoat with a shawl collar to wear underneath his coat.



Lounge suit Conservative politician Anthony Eden was a fashion leader. His trademark outfit was a white linen waistcoat worn with a lounge suit and his favourite silk-brimmed homburg hat, which became known as the “Anthony Eden”.



1936

White suit Born in Corsica, singer Tino Rossi performed in clubs on the French Riviera before moving to Paris in the 1930s. White suits were usually for resort wear, and were accessorized with white or tan and white shoes.